▼ GLASSHOUSE



HISTORY LESSONS

Congress leader **Jairam Ramesh** staged a Parliament-corridor intervention on December 11, intercepting Union defence minister **Rajnath Singh** and pressing into his hands a set of original diary entries by Maniben Patel, daughter of Vallabhbhai Patel. The Congress has been on attack mode ever since the defence minister remarked at a meeting in Vadodara that Jawaharlal Nehru had wanted state funds to build the Babri Masjid but Patel stopped him. Rajnath's office says it had cited *Inside Story of Sardar Patel (The Diary of Maniben Patel 1936–50)* by Prabha Chopra, published in 2011, to bolster the claim. But Ramesh says the entries published in the 2025 volume, *Samarpit Padchhayo Sardarno*, by R.S. Patel ('Aaresh') demolish Rajnath's version. It seems, in politics, it takes only one diary to spark a new version of history.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ THE PEACE SIGN

SABARMATI SURPRISE

In a moment that would have been unimaginable just a decade ago, Union home minister **Amit Shah** was seen praising former rival **Anandiben Patel** at the launch of the Gujarati edition of her biography, *Chunotiya Mujhe Pasand Hai* (I Like Challenges), in Ahmedabad. Once fierce adversaries in BJP's internal power battles, the two appeared to have settled their differences. Shah hailed Anandiben's journey—from schoolteacher to state chief minister to Uttar Pradesh governor—as a story of grit and purpose, even crediting her with organisational innovations. For the audience, the event, held on the banks of the Sabarmati, did more than revisit her life story. It revived memories of old rivalries, reminding everyone that even sworn opponents can share a stage when the spotlight demands it.

